

Northstar Technologies

Employee Handbook & Workplace Operations Guide

Document version: 2026.1

Purpose: This synthetic handbook is designed as a realistic multi-page document for document ingestion, chunking, metadata, retrieval, evaluation, and RAG practice.

Note: This is fictional training content and is not an actual company policy.

1. Company Overview

Northstar Technologies is a fictional software company that develops cloud platforms, internal business applications, mobile products, and developer tools. The organization operates through distributed engineering, product, design, customer success, finance, and operations teams.

The company follows a documentation-first approach. Teams are expected to record important decisions, operational procedures, ownership information, and customer-impacting changes in approved systems.

1.1 Working Principles

- **Customer focus:** Product and engineering decisions should consider measurable customer impact.
- **Ownership:** Every production service should have a clearly identified technical owner and backup owner.
- **Security by default:** Sensitive information must only be stored and shared through approved systems.
- **Operational discipline:** Production changes should be traceable through tickets, pull requests, or approved change records.
- **Continuous learning:** Teams are encouraged to conduct retrospectives and document lessons from incidents.

1.2 Departments

Engineering owns software development and production services. Product manages product direction and requirements. Customer Success handles customer relationships and escalations. Finance manages payroll, expenses, billing, and financial controls. People Operations manages employee programs, leave administration, onboarding, and workplace policies.

2. Working Hours, Attendance, and Remote Work

Northstar uses a flexible working model. Standard collaboration hours are 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM local time on business days. Employees may arrange their remaining working hours around team needs, customer commitments, and approved schedules.

2.1 Attendance

Employees should maintain accurate attendance records where required by their team or local office. Repeated unexplained absence may be escalated to the employee's manager and People Operations.

2.2 Remote Work

Remote employees are responsible for maintaining a suitable workspace, reliable connectivity, and appropriate protection for company information. Company equipment must not be left unattended in public locations.

2.3 Office Access

Employees working from company offices must use their assigned access badge. Visitors must follow reception procedures and remain accompanied in restricted areas.

2.4 Public Holidays

The holiday calendar depends on the employee's assigned country and office. Employees should consult the current regional holiday calendar before planning leave.

2.5 Overtime

Certain teams may require work outside standard hours during incidents, customer escalations, or scheduled releases. Managers should plan such work in advance where practical and follow applicable local employment requirements.

3. Leave and Time Off

Employees are encouraged to take regular time away from work. Leave balances and eligibility depend on employment terms and regional rules.

3.1 Annual Leave

Full-time employees receive 20 annual leave days per calendar year unless their employment agreement or local statutory requirements provide a different entitlement. New employees may receive a prorated entitlement based on their joining date.

3.2 Sick Leave

Employees who are unable to work because of illness should notify their manager as early as reasonably possible. Medical documentation may be requested where required by local policy or law.

3.3 Parental Leave

Parental leave is administered according to the employee's region, employment terms, and applicable statutory requirements. Employees should contact People Operations before the expected leave period to confirm documentation and timelines.

3.4 Leave Approval

Planned leave should normally be submitted through the approved leave system. Managers should review requests promptly while balancing business continuity and team coverage.

3.5 Carry Forward

Unused annual leave may be carried forward only where permitted by the applicable regional policy. Any expiration or carry-forward limits are communicated through the employee's regional policy documents.

4. Compensation, Payroll, and Expenses

Salary is processed according to the payroll schedule applicable to the employee's employing entity. Employees should keep personal bank and tax information current in the approved HR system.

4.1 Payroll Changes

Changes to bank accounts, tax declarations, or other payroll information should be submitted through approved channels before the applicable payroll cutoff. Employees should not send sensitive payroll information through public chat channels.

4.2 Business Expenses

Reasonable business expenses may be reimbursed when they are necessary for approved business activities and supported by required receipts or documentation.

4.3 Expense Submission

Expense claims should normally be submitted within 30 days of the expense date unless a regional policy specifies a different deadline. Managers may request additional business justification for unusual expenses.

4.4 Travel

Business travel should be approved before booking whenever practical. Employees should use preferred travel providers and reasonable fare classes consistent with the applicable travel policy.

4.5 Equipment

Company equipment remains company property unless a written transfer agreement states otherwise. Employees are responsible for reasonable care, secure storage, and timely reporting of loss or damage.

5. Information Security and Data Protection

Employees must protect company, customer, and employee information from unauthorized access, disclosure, alteration, or loss. Security requirements apply whether an employee is working from an office, home, or another location.

5.1 Passwords and Authentication

Employees must use unique passwords for company systems and must not share passwords with coworkers. Multi-factor authentication should be enabled wherever the service supports it.

5.2 Sensitive Information

Customer records, authentication secrets, financial information, private employee information, and production credentials must be handled only through approved systems. Sensitive information should not be copied into personal cloud storage or unapproved messaging services.

5.3 Security Incidents

Suspected phishing, credential exposure, lost devices, unauthorized access, or accidental disclosure should be reported through the security incident channel immediately. Employees should preserve relevant evidence and avoid deleting suspicious messages before guidance is received.

5.4 Device Security

Company-managed laptops should use screen locking, supported operating system versions, and required endpoint protection. Employees should install security updates within the timeframe communicated by IT or Security.

5.5 Access Reviews

System owners periodically review access permissions. Employees should request only the access needed for their responsibilities and should promptly report access that is no longer required.

6. Engineering and Software Development Practices

Engineering teams use version control, code review, automated testing, issue tracking, and deployment procedures appropriate to each service.

6.1 Pull Requests

Production code changes should normally be submitted through a pull request. Reviewers should consider correctness, maintainability, security, test coverage, and operational impact.

6.2 Testing

Changes should include appropriate automated tests where practical. Critical services may require unit, integration, API, and end-to-end tests depending on the risk of the change.

6.3 Production Changes

Production deployments should be traceable to an approved change, pull request, or release record. High-risk changes may require additional review, staged rollout, or rollback preparation.

6.4 Database Changes

Schema changes should use version-controlled migration scripts. Destructive changes require careful review and, where appropriate, a rollback or recovery plan.

6.5 Logging

Application logs should contain enough information to diagnose failures without unnecessarily exposing secrets, passwords, authentication tokens, or sensitive personal information.

7. Incident Management

An incident is an event that causes or threatens significant degradation of a production service, customer experience, security posture, or critical business operation.

7.1 Severity

Severity	Typical Meaning	Initial Response
SEV-1	Critical customer or business impact	Immediate response and incident leadership
SEV-2	Major degradation with meaningful impact	Prompt engineering response and monitoring
SEV-3	Limited impact or workaround available	Normal incident process and planned resolution
SEV-4	Minor issue or informational event	Track and address through normal work

7.2 Incident Process

The incident lead coordinates response, establishes communication cadence, assigns owners, and ensures that customer-facing teams receive appropriate updates. Engineers should focus on mitigation first and deeper root-cause investigation after service stability is restored.

7.3 Post-Incident Review

Significant incidents should have a written review covering impact, timeline, contributing factors, detection, response, recovery, and follow-up actions. Reviews should focus on system and process improvements rather than personal blame.

8. Customer Support and Service Operations

Customer-facing teams classify requests according to urgency, business impact, and contractual commitments. Engineering may be involved when an issue requires technical investigation.

8.1 Escalations

Support should include reproducible steps, affected account or tenant identifiers where permitted, timestamps, relevant error messages, and other useful diagnostic information when escalating an issue.

8.2 Service Level Targets

Response and resolution targets depend on the service agreement and support plan. Internal targets should not be represented to customers as contractual commitments unless they are part of an approved agreement.

8.3 Customer Data

Employees should access customer data only when necessary for an approved business purpose. Screenshots and exported records should be handled according to the applicable data protection requirements.

8.4 Maintenance Windows

Planned maintenance should be communicated through approved operational channels with expected start time, expected duration, customer impact, and rollback considerations.

9. Workplace Conduct and Communication

Employees are expected to communicate respectfully and professionally. Teams should encourage constructive disagreement, clear ownership, and timely escalation of concerns.

9.1 Meetings

Meeting organizers should provide an agenda when practical and share decisions or action items for meetings that require follow-up. Teams should avoid unnecessary recurring meetings.

9.2 Written Communication

Important operational decisions should be documented in systems that the relevant team can access. Private messages should not be the sole record for critical production decisions.

9.3 Conflicts of Interest

Employees should disclose potential conflicts of interest through the appropriate People Operations or compliance channel. The company may request additional information to evaluate the situation.

9.4 Workplace Concerns

Employees may raise workplace concerns through their manager, People Operations, or another approved reporting channel. Reports should be handled according to applicable company procedures and local requirements.

10. Onboarding and Offboarding

10.1 New Employee Onboarding

New employees typically receive an account, device or approved equipment, security training, role-specific access, and an introduction to their team. Managers should establish initial responsibilities and relevant documentation.

10.2 Access Provisioning

Access should follow least-privilege principles. Managers and system owners are responsible for approving access appropriate to the employee's role.

10.3 Role Changes

When an employee changes teams or responsibilities, access should be reviewed and adjusted. The previous team's system permissions should not remain indefinitely when they are no longer required.

10.4 Offboarding

When employment ends, company access is disabled according to the applicable offboarding procedure. Company equipment, credentials, documents, and other property must be returned or handled according to instructions.

10.5 Knowledge Transfer

Employees leaving a role should document active projects, operational responsibilities, known risks, and important contacts. Managers should identify owners for critical services before the employee's final working day.

11. Frequently Asked Questions

How many annual leave days are provided?

Full-time employees generally receive 20 annual leave days per calendar year, subject to employment terms and regional requirements.

When should planned leave be submitted?

Planned leave should normally be submitted through the approved leave system so managers can review coverage.

What should I do if I lose my company laptop?

Report the loss through the security or IT incident channel immediately and follow the instructions provided by the response team.

How should production credentials be stored?

Production credentials should be stored only in approved secret-management or credential systems and must not be committed to source control.

How long do I have to submit an expense?

Expense claims should normally be submitted within 30 days unless the applicable regional policy specifies another deadline.

Who owns a production service?

Each production service should have a clearly identified technical owner and backup owner.

What should be included in a production incident review?

The review should cover impact, timeline, contributing factors, detection, response, recovery, and follow-up actions.

Can company data be stored in personal cloud storage?

Sensitive company information should not be copied to personal cloud storage or other unapproved systems.

How are database schema changes handled?

Schema changes should use version-controlled migration scripts and destructive changes require appropriate review and recovery planning.

Where should important engineering decisions be documented?

Important operational and engineering decisions should be recorded in approved systems accessible to the relevant team.

End of synthetic training document.